convenient room for that purpose. The two free wards or night-rooms for debtors, are at another part of the yard. The way to them is through the women felons' night-room, which has no window. The day-room (called the round house) for men and women felons is in the middle of the area; only fourteen feet by twelve.[1] Near it is a hand-ventilator (which is kept in order for a guinea a year) for airing the men felons' dungeon, which is twenty-six steps under ground, and circular, eighteen feet diameter, with barrack-bedsteads. Over it is an aperture in the court, three feet diameter, with iron grates. The felons work the ventilator cheerfully about a quarter of an hour before they go down, and as long when they come up; for it freshens and cools the dungeon amazingly: we could hardly keep our candle burning below while it was working.[2] There is another very damp dungeon fifteen and a half feet square, the window (eighteen inches by twelve) even with the ground. Straw, £4 a year. Excellent water at a pump in the yard. No infirmary. Mr. Hallward, the surgeon, caught the gaol-fever some years ago, and has ever since been fearful of going into the dungeon: when any felon is sick there, he orders him to be brought out. The smallpox was in this gaol; and at my last visit I found the gaol-fever prevailing, which had carried off some of the prisoners, the gaoler, and Dr. Johnstone, a physician, whose humanity had led him to attend the prison.[3] Two rooms were taken from the bridewell for the sick, who lay in their clothes on straw. At my request, the irons of those who were ill were taken off.

[1] The magistrates may be fully convinced of the impropriety and shocking indecency of having only one day-room, if they examine the women lately sent from this gaol to the bridewell.

[2] The celebrated contrivance of ventilators has been so little attended to in practice, that in all the prisons in this kingdom there are but six of these machines, viz. at Maidstone and Bedford, where they are worked with sails; at London bridewell, Worcester Castle, Stafford, and Shrewsbury; and the two latter have not been used for many years past. This sufficiently shows how liable any new regulation is to fall into neglect, if not constantly the object of care and attention. With respect to ventilators, however, I am now fully confirmed in an opinion I have long entertained, that they are inadequate to the purpose of preventing, and still more of eradicating, the gaol-distemper, while the use of dungeons is continued.

[3] A letter from Dr. Johnstone, senior, dated 18 December, 1783, informs me of the following fact: "A prisoner some time ago dismissed from the gaol here, carried the fever to his own family in Droitwich, six miles from this place, and famous for its salt springs and works; a place where fevers have seldom been heard of but from contagion: the contagion from the above occasion has spread to the poor neighbours of the family above-mentioned, and fourteen individuals have already died of it."

The uneasy situation of the prisoners at night in the horrid dungeon, has, I doubt not, been one cause of their illness; for even in this strong and deep dungeon, prisoners (as in too many other gaols) are all night chained together, by a heavy chain through the links in their fetters and iron rings fastened to the floor.

There is now a useless tub lined with lead, called a bath. Such a bath as there is in the county infirmary, might save the lives of many prisoners.

STAFFORDSHIRE

COUNTY BRIDEWELL

STAFFORD. At the north gate. Three rooms for men and two for women. A room below (called the dungeon) with four apertures about three inches square. No employment. Prisoners always shut up, and in irons; the small court not secure.

SHROPSHIRE

COUNTY GAOL AT SHREWSBURY

This prison was built, as by date in the debtors' court, 1705. Separate courts for debtors and felons; but the latter have no water. For this reason, and because their day-room is in the debtors' court, both debtors and felons are commonly together in that court. Commodious apartments for master's-side debtors: and two large free wards for the common-side. For felons there are two night-dungeons down eleven steps: that for men was a few years ago made more airy by an additional window: and might be freshened by a hand-ventilator which is in the room over the chapel, but has not been used for many years. The women's dungeon might also be freshened by the same. The day-room for felons is small, fifteen and a half feet by five and a half: a separate day-room is necessary to prevent the dreadful consequences of the men and women being together. Most of the women when moved to the bridewell are with child. The county has enclosed another court, which I thought had been designed for women, but it has not yet been used. Here are three large lamps in the court supplied at the county's expense.